

שליח
עושה
שליח

TOOLS

Toward HEALTHY COMMUNICATION

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→ THE INTRODUCTION TO THIS
ARTICLE AND SOME OF THE TOOLS
THAT FOLLOW HAVE BEEN ADAPTED
FROM A WORKSHOP DELIVERED BY
RABBI GORDON AH AT A KINUS
HASHLUCHIM.

While the concept of shlichus traces its way back to the times of Avrohom Avinu and Eliezer, empowering shluchim to hire new shluchim and grant them positions of leadership and power in their local and neighboring communities—shliach oseh shliach—was very much an innovation of our Rebbe.

This groundbreaking concept has allowed the family of shluchim to expand exponentially over the last number of decades and reach countless more Yidden than was ever possible. To keep up with the changing environment of shlichus, personal change is necessary as well. This article provides tried-and-true tools to help foster healthy communication between shluchim.

REMEMBER THAT
EVERY SHLIACH
IS A SHLIACH
OF THE REBBE.

1
THOUGH A PERSON'S SHLICHUS MAY COME ABOUT THROUGH ONE HUNDRED INTERMEDIARIES, IT IS STILL THE REBBE WHO HAS SENT HIM.

2

Remember that the Rebbe IS THE ONE WHO SET UP THE SYSTEM OF SHLIACH OSEH SHLIACH. MAKING IT WORK GIVES TREMENDOUS NACHAS TO THE REBBE, WHILE FAILURE, CHAS V'SHOLOM, DOES THE VERY OPPOSITE.

Let's make it work!

3

SET CLEAR GOALS AND MEASURABLE OUTCOMES.

It is important that both the "employer" shliach and the "employee" shliach each have written goals and measurable outcomes through which to determine whether those goals are being reached. This is true for both the general shlichus goals (develop a youth minyan, run Friendship Circle, etc.), as well as specific jobs at each event. Each having

tasks clearly defined on shared to-do lists, along with regular meetings to track progress, helps both parties meet their personal and collective long-term and short-term goals. Write down the answers to these questions:

1. What does success look like?
2. What are the minimum requirements?
3. When do we touch base?
4. Whom do I go to when I have a question?
5. What are policies set by the "employer" shliach?
6. What areas can be left up to the "employee" shliach?





SCHEDULE WEEKLY MEETINGS.

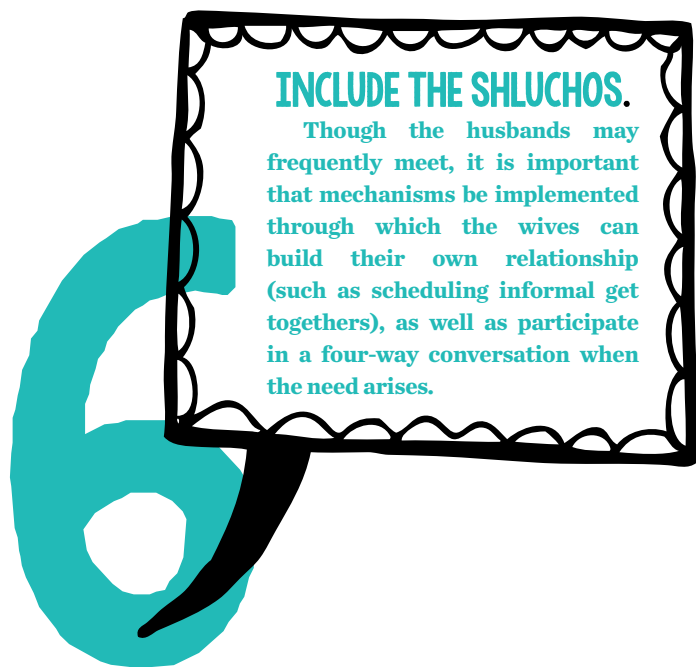
Hold them sacred and do not postpone them. Meeting once a week at a set time and location, with a written agenda, in order to review where things are at and whether expectations are being met helps create a natural

rhythm of conversation and creates the opportunity to discuss issues without fear and anxiety that there will be hard feelings. Small challenges or misunderstandings can be resolved before they build up, fester, and become sinister.



Write it down.

Jotting down pointers as reminders of what you'd like to discuss at your meeting helps keep the conversation focused, as well as lessens the likelihood that you'll forget to speak about something significant. Similarly, wrapping up a meeting with a written summary or minutes and a list of next-actions (along with who is to be taking care of them) is important. In addition to providing clarity, the list is also a great follow-up tool.



INCLUDE THE SHLUCHOS.

Though the husbands may frequently meet, it is important that mechanisms be implemented through which the wives can build their own relationship (such as scheduling informal get togethers), as well as participate in a four-way conversation when the need arises.



SHOW APPRECIATION.

Though this may not come naturally to some people, it is important to frequently show appreciation for that which is going well. There are many ways to express gratitude. It is worthwhile to expend energy to discover what form appeals most to the person in question and to make the effort to do so. Lack of positive recognition creates uncertainty, anxiety, and is the breeding ground for unhappiness. Avoid praising the shliach in general terms, such as "the best." Instead, praise the specific work and accomplishments of the shliach. For example, "The Purim party was a real draw this year! The energy, entertainment, and food all got rave reviews."



Make a CHESHBON HANEFESH.

"Am I being fair? Am I expressing myself in a respectful, non-arrogant manner?" Nobody is perfect and it is to be expected that there will be ups and downs. As such, there is no need to overplay and overdramatize when there are mistakes.

COMMUNICATE RESPECT.

The way fellow shluchim communicate with each other is a reflection of how they represent the meshaleach just as much as when they put on tefillin with a karkafta. This includes listening respectfully when the other is speaking, not making things personal, admitting mistakes, accepting a different perspective, etc.



Speak about the object, NOT THE SUBJECT.

Begin by validating the person and then focus on the problem, not the person: "I need your help in getting back on track. Tell me your thoughts about what's going on?"

Instead of asking "Why did you do this?" (which automatically puts a person on the defensive—even if he's done nothing wrong) you can say, "I need your help with...." or "Can you please tell me about...." Confrontation is avoided and collaboration becomes the name of the game. Continue asking open ended questions that allow the other shliach to share his side of the story: "Tell me more." "Why do you think that happened?" "What can I do to help?" "What might you do to help?" (Of course, these questions must be asked sincerely in order not to come across as patronizing.)

11

TALK, DON'T TEXT.

Eighty percent of communication is through body language, all of which is lost in text messaging. If a difficult issue arises, do not send messages about it via text or email. Speak,

preferably face-to-face. And while you're at it, make sure that you're not hastening your point for lack of time or checking your email during the chat. The success of this conversation is as important as anything else in your shlichus.

12

Be curious
INSTEAD OF ACCUSATORY
OR JUDGMENTAL.

Instead of saying, "Why did you...?" say, "I'm wondering whether you can share the thought process you had when you...." Instead of saying, "Why are you late?" say, "I'm wondering whether there is anything I can do to help you start programs more punctually." It is respectful to begin a question with "I'm wondering...."

13

IMPROVE YOUR
listening **SKILLS.**

Some people are naturally not great listeners. If you do not possess that skill set, take the time to learn how to gain it. It will be worth your while. One great way to start is by simply waiting until the other person finishes speaking before responding. Though you may feel you already know where the monologue is headed and don't want to waste time, waiting those extra few moments will make the speaker feel respected and may also surprise you with information or a perspective you may not have expected to hear. Lean in, look into the person's eyes, nod your head, and paraphrase what the speaker has said. Then ask, "Is that it?" and repeat until you get a "Yes, that's all."

Don't be afraid to have a difficult conversation.

BE SENSITIVE AND RESPECTFUL, BUT BE HONEST.
NO WALKING ON EGGHELLS. BEGIN BY STATING THE PROBLEM IN ONE SENTENCE. "I NEED YOUR HELP WITH SOMETHING. I FEEL IT IS UNPROFESSIONAL TO START OUR EVENTS LATE."

15

DEFINE IT.

Friction and tension are often overstated, dramatized, and not properly defined, so they metastasize and takes on a life of their own. Disagreement is not abnormal. It has its place but should be contained, defined, articulated, written down, and put into proper context. Then, a structure should be created to deal with it. Diagnosing the problem is half the solution.

16

Never say **"NEVER."**
ABSOLUTE TERMS, SUCH AS "NEVER" AND "ALWAYS," SHOULD BE AVOIDED.

17

Don't
OVER-COMMUNICATE.

NOT EVERY THOUGHT THAT COMES TO MIND NEEDS TO BE COMMUNICATED. SOMETIMES WE NEED TO LET THINGS GO. ASSESS AND DISCRIMINATE.

18

Don't
SHARE YOUR FRUSTRATIONS ABOUT YOUR FELLOW SHLIACH WITH YOUR SPOUSE, CHILDREN, OR BAALEI BATIM.

Aside from the loshon hora angle, long after you will have forgotten about the incident, the listener will harbor resentment against that person and your words will come back to haunt you.

19

BE A MENTCH.

Period. Nothing can ever replace that. It may not be easy to define but it's a part of the equation that should not be understated. Follow the golden rule: treat your fellow shliach like you wish to be treated.



When ALL ELSE FAILS

SOMETIMES A PERSON MAY FEEL that the attempts and efforts to build a positive relationship are only being put forth by him. Naturally, this will create feelings of frustration, disappointment, and even bitterness. He can choose to accept this reality, or to quit, or to vent to his brother-in-law. He can also choose to make it part of his shlichus to treat his employer/employee better. Unfortunately, the negative feelings and behaviors being exhibited are often simply a byproduct of tremendous stress in other areas of the person's life and do not necessarily reflect the "real numbers" of what is being put forth by the other person. Making it his business to build up (in an honest way) the self esteem of the employer/employee—treating him like his biggest baal habos (after all, he gives x amount of money or services per year)—may sometimes help out. Some ways this can be done are by meeting every week, asking him for advice, including him in your life, and making him feel good about himself and what he is doing, as well as what you are doing. Additionally, since most shluchim have not been trained to be employers/employees, and may simply not be aware of the value of setting measurable goals, defining success, etc., perhaps there is a way you can gently guide him through the process. Though this may be uncomfortable, it is far more pleasant than arguing.

If both parties are already following all the good practices suggested in this article and are still not able to communicate or agree on a specific point, it's time to consult with a neutral third party. That person does not have to be a professional mediator, just someone seasoned whom they both respect.

התייחסות ישירה אל המשלח

ולהוסיף ולהדגיש, שבשליחות זו נכללים לא רק אלו שנתמנו ע"י כ"ק מו"ח אדמו"ר נשיא דורנו, בחיים חיותו בעלמא דין, אלא גם אלו שנתמנו לאח"ז, בכחו ובשליחותו, ובזה גופא — באופן ד"שליח עושה שליח עד מאה שלוחים", ו"מאה" לאו דוקא, אלא, להורות על הריבוי כו', וכן אלו שנעשו "שלוחים" ביזמתם, כלומר, שנדבה רוחם להתגייס לעבודת השליחות דכ"ק מו"ח אדמו"ר נשיא דורנו.

ולהעיר, שגם אלו שנתמנו (או התנדבו כו') באמצעות שליח, כאמור, שליח עושה שליח — מתייחסים למשלח עצמו באופן ישיר, שלא ע"י השתלשלות המדרגות שבינתיים, ע"ד ובדוגמת הענין דהשתלשלות הכתרים זה מזה, שבחי' הכתר דעולם שלמטה נשתלשל (לא מבחי' המלכות דעולם שלמעלה ממנו, אלא) מבחי' הכתר דעולם שלמעלה, עד לבחי' הכתר בדרגא הכי נעלית.

משיחת ש"פ תולדות תשמ"ח

(תורת מנחם תשמ"ח ח"א ע' 508 - 507)

I would like to emphasize that the shlichus [initiated by the Friediker Rebbe] does not only include those who were appointed by the [Friediker] Rebbe during his lifetime, but also those who were appointed afterward, with his koach and on his behalf.

Furthermore, it includes a shliach who was appointed by another shliach, who in turn appoints a third shliach, and so on, "until one hundred shluchim." (The number "one hundred" is not to be taken literally; it implies a large number.)

Similarly, it includes those who became shluchim on their own initiative, who stepped forward to join the avodas hashlichus of the Rebbe, nesi doreinu.

We should point out that although these shluchim were appointed (or volunteered) via other shluchim, they relate directly to the meshalei'ach himself, without a hishtalshelus through the people in between. This is similar to the concept of השתלשלות הכתרים זה מזה, in which the kesser of a lower world is nishtalshel (not from the malchus of the world above it, but) directly from the kesser of the higher world, until kesser in its highest form.

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MRS. ELKY RAITPORT



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